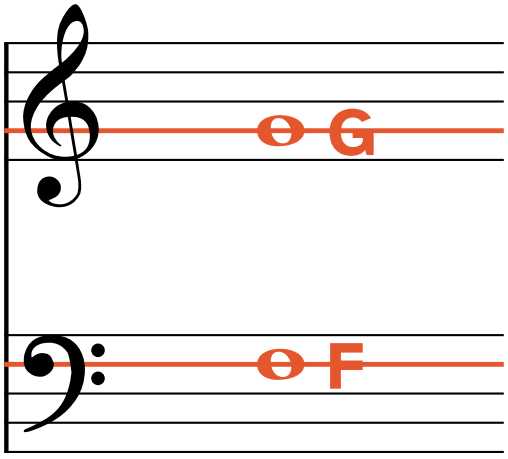
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.





Treble clef
curls round line 2: G

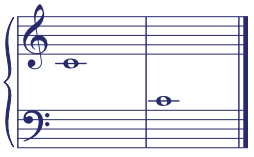


Bass clef
its dots hug line 4: F

Look closely: the treble clef curls round G · the bass clef's dots hug F

The grand staff

Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.

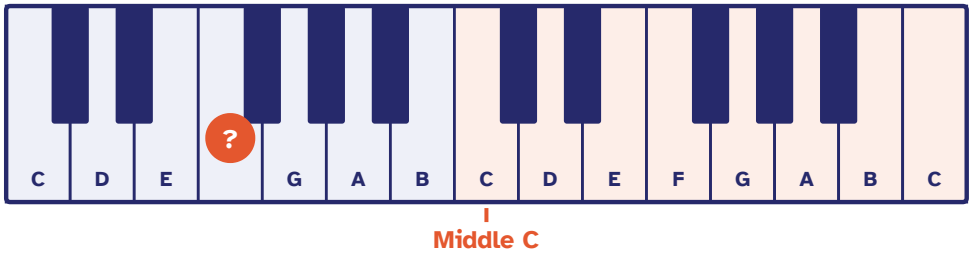


Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE

Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

GAME

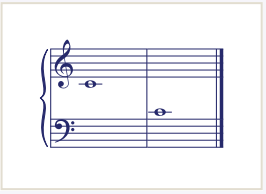
Treble or bass?

1. the G above Middle C
2. the lowest key on the piano
3. Middle C
4. High C

Which staff would each note be written on?

Answer: 1 treble · 2 bass · 3 either: it sits between the two · 4 treble.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
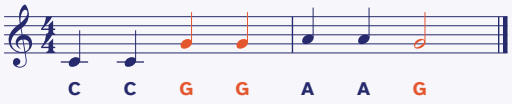


Point, then play.

Point to the line the treble clef curls round and play that G, the G just above Middle C. Point to the line between the bass clef's dots and play that F, the F just below Middle C.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to. Read the round head, not the stem: the stem never changes the note.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same five lines read as different notes, depending on which pair you put on.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO
The staff and the keyboard p. 29 · Reading the notes p. 32

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs